



SHUTTERSTOCK

SIKKIM

GURUDONGMAR

The dispute began when the property was transferred from the Muzrai department to the Wakf list

custodian—the Sajjadah Nashin—and the Hindu plaintiffs for not claiming the shrine as belonging to one or the other community.

Over the years, a series of court cases followed amid allegations of mismanagement of the shrine; the demand by Hindu groups via a trust called the Sri Guru Dattatreya Peeta Devasthana Samvardhana Samithi for a Hindu priest to officiate over the pooja rituals that the Sajjadah Nashin was overseeing; and petitions by civil society groups alarmed by the turn of events. ■

–Ajay Sukumaran

FORCE MAJEURE

It was never a gurudwara," insists Gangtok advocate Jorgay Namka. "It is still a gurudwara," counters the retired Col. Dalvinder S. Grewal. The bitter dispute reflected in these opinions can be traced back to 1987 when Grewal, then a battery commander, sponsored the construction of a small 'gurudwara' on the pristine shores of the Gurudongmar lake, 18,000 feet above sea level on the Indian fringe of the Tibetan Plateau. Grewal and his men were motivated by a belief that the beautiful lake, its name and local traditions surrounding it must be associated with Guru Nanak. A few years later, another Sikh officer posted to the area oversaw an expansion of this building, and allegedly the destruction of a small votive structure known as a *Sangphur*, used for incense and butter lamps. Meanwhile, further down the road in the Lachen valley, a Sikh JCO helped establish what is now the substantial Gurudwara Nanak Lama Sahib in the town of Chungthang. This, too, was seemingly inspired by the plainsmen's conviction that local legends about a great 'Guru Rinpoche' were proof of Guru Nanak's sojourn in this valley.

The native Buddhists of Lachen may well have been irked by the proliferation of the soldiers' narratives. Particularly when places traditionally associated with Guru Rinpoche Padmasambhava, the legendary missionary credited with bringing Vajrayana Buddhism to the Himalaya and Tibet in the 8th century, were linked to miracles performed by the 15th century founder of Sikhism, Guru Nanak. Even the name of Changthang came to be frequently interpreted as a corruption of '*Changa sthaan*'. Nice place.

While that may sound like a bad Punjabi joke, local representative Anung Lachenpa, 'Pipon of the Lachen Dzomsa', was clearly not amused. In a statement published in 1987, which is